



AFTER

By the summer of 1864, Gettysburg and the other Union victories of the previous July had faded in the Northern public's memory and were replaced by stalemate, immense bloodshed, and defeat.

MORALE EBBS AND FLOWS

President **Lincoln needed victories** as much as, if not more than, his Confederate counterpart, Jefferson Davis. Lincoln's reelection in November 1864 depended on Northern civilian perceptions of the war. General William T. [Sherman's capture of Atlanta](#) in September helped turn the tide of Northern feeling. By year's end, Sherman had reached Savannah—[the March to the Sea](#)—while in Virginia Confederate General Robert E. Lee was **stuck in a [siege at Petersburg](#)**. Now Southern morale plummeted, encouraging desertion from already depleted armies.